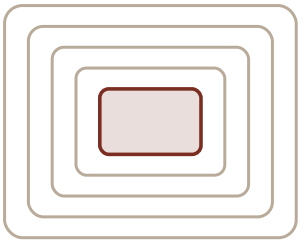
A DISSERTATION



ECDYSIS

Exoskeletal Subjectivity, the Cold Berserk, and the Judgment of Arms in John Steakley's Armor

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Abstract

This dissertation reads John Steakley's *Armor* (DAW Books, 1984) as the most rigorous literary anatomy of a condition it names *exoskeletal subjectivity*: the state of a self that survives catastrophic violence by relocating its structural integrity from an interior core to an exterior shell. Against the critical commonplace that treats the novel as a darker gloss on Robert A. Heinlein's *Starship Troopers* (1959) and an affective cousin of Joe Haldeman's *The Forever War* (1974), it argues that Steakley's titular figure is plural and nested. The nuclear-powered suit is a *technical* exoskeleton; the "Engine," the dissociated combat persona of the scout Felix, is a *psychic* exoskeleton; the suit's battle recorder, whose stored "memory" Jack Crow and the project director Hollis "Holly" Ware re-live on the research world Sanction while Lya keeps watch over them, is a *mnemonic* exoskeleton; and celebrity, alias and reputation (Crow's notoriety, Felix's concealment as the drunken rancher Lewis) constitute a *social* exoskeleton. Each shell obeys the logic Freud assigned to the protective shield against stimuli (*Reizschutz*): it preserves life by deadening a layer of it. Proceeding constellationally, and distinguishing documented filiation from structural affinity, the study draws on trauma theory, the philosophy of technology, media archaeology, myrmecology and classical reception.

Five arguments follow. First, the Engine is theorized as a *cold berserk*, categorically distinct from the Achillean berserk that Jonathan Shay identified among Vietnam veterans: an executive automatism in Pierre Janet's sense, which inverts Freud's dictum into *Wo Ich war, soll Es werden* and instantiates, as a personality, the observe-orient-decide-act loop through which 1980s military reform imagined combat itself. Second, the Ants are read as the *faceless absolute*, an enemy outside recognition (Hegel, Kojève), the face (Levinas), the political (Schmitt, Clausewitz) and speech (Arendt), whose pressure produces a *Myrmidonic inversion*: Ovid's ants-made-men run backward, as soldiers become expendable and self-detonating workers. Third, the recorder externalizes *Erlebnis* without *Erfahrung* (Benjamin); its immersion sessions redeem it only by forming a small community of witness against the war's official story, and what they transmit is not competence but conscience. Fourth, the double plot restages the ancient *hoplōn krisis*, the judgment over the arms of Achilles be-

tween the mute warrior Ajax and the eloquent Odysseus, but resolves it by chiasmus: the warrior chooses, as Odysseus' soul does in Plato's Myth of Er, the life of a private man, while the trickster learns to stand; the armor returns to the warrior, who vanishes without a corpse like the "blessed" heroes of Hesiod, the *olbioi* whom Latin would call *felices*. Fifth, the novel's decisive ethical event is *ecdysis*, the molt: Nathan Kent's breaking open of Felix's armor at the cost of his own life.

The dissertation concludes by formulating a *teneral ethic*, named for the entomologist's term for the soft, newly molted insect (from Latin *tener*, "tender"): an ethics of the interval between shells, grounded in vulnerability (Butler, Levinas) and narratability (Arendt, Cavarero), which *Armor* proposes against both Heinlein's civic militarism and the posthumanist celebration of the cyborg.

Felix qui potuit rerum cognoscere causas, / atque metus omnes et inexorabile fatum / subiecit pedibus strepitumque Acherontis avari.

Fortunate the man who could learn the causes of things, and set beneath his feet all fears, inexorable fate, and the roar of greedy Acheron.

VIRGIL, *Georgics* 2.490–492

quantumque ego Marte feroci / inque acie valeo, tantum valet iste loquendo.

As much as I prevail in savage war and in the battle line, so much does he prevail in speaking.

AJAX ON ULYSSES, OVID, *Metamorphoses* 13.11–12

ἡ τοῦ Αἴαντος ἐν Νεκυίᾳ σιωπὴ μέγα καὶ παντὸς ὑψηλότερον λόγου.

The silence of Ajax in the Summoning of the Dead is great, and more sublime than any speech.

[LONGINUS], *On the Sublime* 9.2



INTRODUCTION

The Problem of the Shell

I. THESIS

Armor is a novel about the price of not dying. Its protagonist, the scout Felix, enlists in humanity's war against the insectoid "Ants" in the hope of being killed, and discovers within himself a mechanism, which he calls the Engine, that will not permit it. That paradox, a death wish housed inside an apparatus of survival, has usually been read as psychological realism grafted onto the hardware of *Starship Troopers*. John Clute's entry in *The Encyclopedia of Science Fiction* sets the terms of most commentary when it observes that the novel's plot invites comparison between the mecha its soldiers wear and the psychic armor human beings must grow in order to survive a singularly cruel universe. This dissertation accepts the comparison and radicalizes it. Steakley's subject is not armor as a metaphor for defense but the *exoskeleton* as a total architecture of the self: a body plan in which structure is carried on the outside and the inside is left soft.

The novel has enjoyed a readerly afterlife out of all proportion to its scholarly reception. It is admired as a war story and, more quietly, as a study of what violence does to the persons who survive it; it has been read far less often as a work of thought. The wager of what follows is that *Armor* thinks with unusual precision, and that its precision is architectural rather than discursive. It contains almost no explicit philosophy. Its ideas are lodged in its structures: in the topology of a suit, the grammar of a dissociated persona, the itinerary of an object, the chiasmus of two plots.

II. EXOSKELETAL SUBJECTIVITY

Vertebrate anatomy and the philosophical tradition of interiority share a design: a rigid frame within, sensitive and exposed tissue without. Augustine's injunction *noli foras ire, in te ipsum redi; in interiore homine habitat veritas* (*De vera religione* 39.72) locates truth, and with it the integrity of the person, in an inner core. The Cartesian *res cogitans*, Kan-

tian autonomy and the Romantic deep self are variations on that endoskeletal scheme. Arthropods invert it. Their integrity resides in a cuticle that is at once skeleton, armor and sensory surface, while the interior remains comparatively undifferentiated and soft.

Armor records a human being compelled to adopt the arthropod plan. Felix states the topology himself in the novel's most frequently cited passage, describing what the Engine will do on his behalf and concluding: "It will do all this while I cower inside" (Steakley 1984, 18). The sentence is a cross-section. An impersonal *It* performs agency at the outer surface; the *I*, the putative seat of personhood, has contracted into a cowering interior.

I call this configuration *exoskeletal subjectivity*: a mode of selfhood in which the capacities that classical humanism located within (judgment, memory, identity, honor) are relocated to shells that carry them on the outside, at the cost of the interior's atrophy. The novel builds four such shells and nests them. The first is *technical*: the nuclear-powered suit in which infantry are projected onto the planet Banshee by the teleportation system called Transit. The second is *psychic*: the Engine. The third is *mnemonic*: the suit's battle recorder, which stores the wearer's experience while the suit is active and which, later, two men on the research world Sanction will enter and re-live while a third person watches over them. The fourth is *social*: the celebrity that encases Jack Crow; the alias under which Felix hides as the alcoholic rancher Lewis; and, at the scale of the polity, the official story of the war that the recorder contradicts.

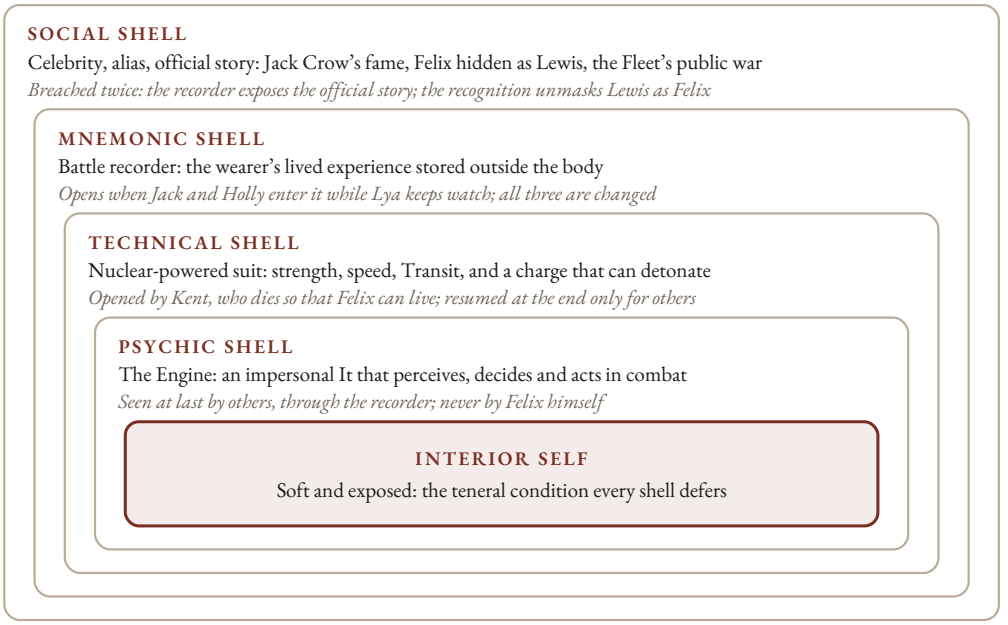


FIGURE 1 *Four nested exoskeletons around the interior self.* Read from the outside in, each band names a shell, what it is in the novel, and the moment at which the novel opens it. Only the interior is never armored, and it is what the teneral ethic of Chapter 8 sets out to protect.

All four shells obey a single law, which Freud formulated in *Jenseits des Lustprinzips* (1920) in his speculative account of the living vesicle. Exposed to overwhelming external energies, the organism's outermost layer ceases to be fully alive and becomes a protective shield (*Reizschutz*) whose partial death preserves the layers beneath; trauma is the breach of that shield. Freud's crust is an exoskeleton described in the vocabulary of metapsychology. Steakley's shells are its technological, psychological, archival and social elaborations, and each exacts the same price: it protects life by mortifying part of it.

III. METHOD: FILIATION, SYNCHRONY, AFFINITY

Any account of "the originators of the ideas" embedded in a literary work requires a distinction that criticism often elides. This study recognizes three registers of relation.

The first is documented *filiation*. It includes Steakley's evident dialogue with Heinlein's powered infantry and insect foe, noted by reviewers from the novel's first decades onward; his reuse of the names Felix and Jack Crow in *Vampire$* (1990), whose copyright page disavows the connection and thereby confirms it; and the archival trace of the nov-

el's genesis, an early manuscript dated 1981 now held among the papers of James Oliver Rigney Jr. (Robert Jordan) at the College of Charleston.

The second is *synchrony*. The novel appeared in December 1984, in a year that also produced William Gibson's *Neuromancer*, James Cameron's *The Terminator*, Paul Virilio's *Guerre et cinéma* and Fredric Jameson's essay on postmodernism and "the waning of affect," four years after the American Psychiatric Association codified post-traumatic stress disorder in DSM-III.

The third, and the most consequential for the argument, is structural *affinity*. The novel independently reconstitutes logics whose originators Steakley need not have read: Ernst Jünger's "second, colder consciousness," Pierre Janet's psychological automatism, Hannah Arendt's daimonic "who," Walter Benjamin's storyteller, Plato's choice of lives. In the epistemo-critical prologue to the *Trauerspiel* study, Benjamin proposed that ideas relate to phenomena as constellations relate to stars. The method here treats its thinkers in that spirit: not as sources the novel draws upon, but as coordinates whose configuration the novel renders legible.

Two conventions follow. Citations of *Armor* give part and chapter rather than page, since pagination varies across the DAW first edition, its reprintings and electronic copies; the passage quoted above falls in Part One, at page 18 of the first paperback edition. Plot particulars have been checked against the full text, and quotation is confined to a few short phrases. The novel is divided into five parts and an epilogue (Felix; Jack Crow; Puppy in a Well; Everybody's Hero; Armor), and Part Four renders what the recorder holds. Synopses follow the novel's own order of disclosure, in which Felix's ordeal on Banshee is interrupted, later in story-time, by Jack Crow's first-person narrative on Sanction, and in which the two strands are braided together through immersion in the recorder until Lewis the rancher is revealed to be Felix.

IV. CONTRIBUTIONS AND PLAN

The dissertation makes four claims to originality. It introduces *exoskeletal subjectivity* as a category for literary and cultural analysis. It distinguishes the *cold berserk* from the hot berserk of the trauma literature. It recovers the novel's mythic armature as a *hoplōn krisis*, a judgment of arms, resolved by chiasmus. And it formulates, from the novel's own logic, a *teneral ethic* of the interval between shells.

The chapters move outward through the shells and then inward toward their shedding. Chapter 1 situates the novel in its annus mirabilis and in the lineage of "bug war" fiction. Chapter 2 examines the technical exoskeleton through the philosophy of prosthesis, from Ernst Kapp's organ projection and Freud's *Prothesengott* to Marshall McLuhan's autoamputation and Donna Haraway's cyborg. Chapter 3 theorizes the En-

gine as a cold berserk, an executive automatism that inverts Freud's topography and installs the military-cybernetic decision loop as a personality. Chapter 4 reads the Ants as the *faceless absolute* and traces the *Myrmidonic inversion* by which those who fight insects become insect-like. Chapter 5 treats the battle recorder as a mnemonic exoskeleton whose redemption lies in testimony rather than extraction. Chapter 6 reads Jack Crow's celebrity as a social exoskeleton and Crow himself as a trickster whose gift of the armor is a Trojan horse that conquers its giver. Chapter 7 reconstructs the judgment of arms. Chapter 8 proposes *ecdysis*, the molt, as the novel's ethical event. The conclusion considers the novel's bearing on contemporary war media and on the present wager that competence can be distilled from recorded behavior.



CHAPTER ONE

Annus Mirabilis

1984, the Bug War, and the Afterlife of Vietnam

1.1 AUTHOR AND ARCHIVE

John William Steakley Jr. (1951–2010) was born in Cleburne, Texas, and lived most of his life in that state, apart from brief periods in South America and in Hollywood, where he went at the invitation of the screenwriter L. M. "Kit" Carson and which, by his family's account, he came to dislike. He took a BA in English at Southern Methodist University and published his first professional story, "The Bluenose Limit," in *Amazing Stories* in March 1981, followed by "Flyer" in 1982. He contributed to Robert Adams's *Horseclans* shared-world anthologies and completed only two novels: *Armor* (1984) and *Vampire$* (1990), the latter filmed by John Carpenter as *Vampires* (1998). A sequel to *Armor* occupied him for years and remained unfinished at his death; a prologue was posted online.

The slenderness of the oeuvre is itself a datum. *Armor* reads less as a career novel than as a singular act of working-through. Its manuscript, dated 1981, places its composition squarely in the years in which American culture was deciding what the Vietnam War had meant and what it had done to those who fought it.

1.2 THE LINEAGE OF THE BUG WAR

Heinlein's *Starship Troopers* (1959) established the template: powered suits that multiply a soldier's strength and speed, drops from orbit, and an enemy of arachnid "Bugs" organized in castes around queens and brain-caste coordinators. Heinlein's insects served a Cold War allegory of collectivism. His novel's civic theory, in which the franchise is earned through federal service and a classroom course in moral philosophy instructs re-

cruits that force has settled more historical questions than any other factor, made the suit an emblem of a citizen's earned hardness.

Haldeman's *The Forever War* (1974), written by a wounded veteran of Vietnam, retained the powered suit but reversed the genre's vector. Relativistic time dilation estranges its soldiers from the civilization for which they fight; the war proves to have begun in a misunderstanding; and it ends through communication, once humanity has itself become a cloned collective. Steakley stands between these poles and refuses both. He keeps Heinlein's hardware and insect foe while subtracting his political philosophy: no one in *Armor* explains why the war is fought, and the Fleet's institutional intelligence appears chiefly as complacency, incompetence and public relations. He keeps Haldeman's disaffection while subtracting his resolution: there is no misunderstanding to correct, because there is no contact through which understanding could pass.

One year later, Orson Scott Card's *Ender's Game* (1985) and its sequel *Speaker for the Dead* (1986) would give the bug war its empathic turn. The "buggers" are exterminated through a failure of communication, and their exterminator becomes the one who speaks for the dead. *Armor* sits at the hinge of the tradition, after Heinlein's triumphalism and Haldeman's irony and just before Card's remorse, and it does what none of them does. It declines to make the enemy meaningful at all, and it relocates the question of meaning from the alien to the archive: not *who are they?* but *who was he?*

1.3 THE AFTERLIFE OF VIETNAM

The novel's war is not Vietnam allegorized, but it is unmistakably a war imagined after Vietnam. The fort that Felix helps to build on Banshee fills with liaison officers who, its commander explains, have come to watch combat from the safety of the bunker, and then with reporters on a press tour; the official story of the Antwar diverges sharply from what the battle recorder discloses. The repertoire is familiar from the Saigon press briefings derided as the "Five O'Clock Follies," from the body-count metrics of attrition, and from Michael Herr's *Dispatches* (1977), whose soldiers perform for cameras that have already taught them what war should look like. Gustav Hasford's *The Short-Timers* (1979) supplied the period's iconography of the dissociated grunt; Kubrick would adapt it in 1987.

Institutionally, the years of the novel's composition were the years in which the trauma paradigm took shape. Chaim Shatan and Robert Jay Lifton, working with veterans' rap groups, had described a "post-Vietnam syndrome." Lifton's *Home from the War* (1973) extended to returning soldiers the concepts he had developed among the survivors of Hiroshima in *Death in Life* (1967): the death imprint, death guilt, psychic numbing. In 1980 DSM-III codified post-traumatic stress disorder. In the same year Ronald Reagan

called the war a noble cause; in 1982 *First Blood* gave the returning veteran a body that brings the war home, and Maya Lin's memorial gave the dead a polished black wall in which the living see their own reflections among the names.

Susan Jeffords would later name the decade's cultural project the "remasculinization of America" and its emblem the Reagan-era "hard body." *Armor* is the hard body's anatomy lesson. It takes the most literal of hard bodies, a man in nuclear-powered armor, and opens it to show the cowering interior, the second skin that holds it together, and the price of the holding.

1.4 THE CYBORG YEAR

Four other works of 1984 define the field in which *Armor* thinks. Gibson's *Neuromancer* introduced "simstim," a technology by which one person rides another's sensorium, and its hero holds the body's "meat" in contempt; Steakley's recorder makes the same technological promise in the service of an embodiment that cannot be escaped. Cameron's *The Terminator* imagined a killing machine as a metal endoskeleton sheathed in living tissue, immune to argument, negotiation, pity and fear. Steakley's soldier is its exact inverse, living tissue sheathed in a metal exoskeleton, and his Engine is a Terminator grown on the inside of a man who still feels everything.

Virilio's *Guerre et cinéma* argued that the history of battle is the history of mutating fields of perception, and that weapon and camera have co-evolved; *Armor*'s suit is literally both. Jameson's essay on postmodernism diagnosed "the waning of affect," the substitution of free-floating intensities for depth, the passage from Munch's scream to Warhol's surface. The Engine is that waning installed as a survival technique, with the scream sealed inside the surface. Haraway's "Manifesto for Cyborgs," published in *Socialist Review* the following year, described the cyborg as the illegitimate offspring of militarism and patriarchal capitalism, and noted that such offspring are often unfaithful to their origins. Felix, a deserter whose armor ends by defending a planet whose owner permits no private blazers, is that infidelity in narrative form.

Over the whole year stood the title of Orwell's novel, whose telescreens watched every citizen from the wall. *Armor* imagines something more intimate: a recorder that watches its wearer from the inside, and a society that will one day ask to enter what it saw. These synchronies are not decorative. They mark the moment at which the boundaries between body, machine and image were being renegotiated, and at which a newly named psychiatric category had made the soldier's interior a public question. *Armor* is that question posed as an architecture.



CHAPTER TWO

The Technical Exoskeleton

Prosthesis, Speed, and the Self-Detonating Shell

2.1 FROM HEPHAESTUS TO TRANSIT

The armored body has a literary genealogy as old as Western narrative. In *Iliad* 18 Hephaestus forges new arms for Achilles, and the shield's cosmological program (cities at peace and at war, harvest and dance, the encircling river of Ocean) makes armor the bearer of a world. Steakley's suits bear no world. They are nuclear-powered instruments of survival delivered to the planet by Transit, a teleportation system that abolishes the journey to battle, and the novel's first catastrophe follows from that abolition. The thousand-meter crag that Felix's force is sent to take, the Knuckle, proves to be a Hive; the assault is shattered; and the survivors learn that the Ants can lock onto Transit beacons and bombard them with missiles fired from the Hive, so that retreat becomes impossible; the soldiers call these strikes the Hammer. The medium of speed has become a trap.

Paul Virilio's dromology, inaugurated in *Vitesse et politique* (1977), is the theory of that trap. For Virilio, power in modernity is the command of velocity, and every acceleration manufactures its own accident; as he later put it, to invent the ship is to invent the shipwreck. Transit is the absolute acceleration, travel reduced to zero duration, and its specific accident is the beacon converted into a target. The scout's role extends the logic to the individual body: Felix survives in part because scout armor is light and fast. The word itself holds a further irony. *Scout* descends, through Old French *escoute*, from Latin *auscultare*, "to listen." The scout is the one who listens, and in a novel whose second protagonist is a talker, the etymology anticipates the division of labor examined in Chapter 7.

2.2 PROSTHESIS: ORGAN PROJECTION, THE PROSTHETIC GOD, AUTOAMPUTATION

The philosophy of technology offers three classical accounts of the tool's relation to the body, and *Armor* tests all three. Ernst Kapp's *Grundlinien einer Philosophie der Technik* (1877) understood tools as unconscious projections of organs: the hammer projects the fist, the telegraph the nervous system. Powered armor is organ projection at the scale of the whole body, a second and larger body cast around the first.

Freud, in *Das Unbehagen in der Kultur* (1930), turned the account toward ambivalence. Equipped with all his auxiliary organs, man has become *eine Art Prothesengott*, a kind of prosthetic god: magnificent, yet not grown together with his prostheses, which still give him considerable trouble. Felix's suit is the most magnificent of such prostheses, and it is not grown together with him. It is removable, which is the precondition of the novel's decisive ethical act (Chapter 8). It is foreign, which is the precondition of the Engine (Chapter 3).

Marshall McLuhan's *Understanding Media* (1964) completed the triad with a darker thesis. Every extension of the body is also an "autoamputation": the nervous system, overstimulated by the pressure the extension is meant to relieve, protects itself by numbing the extended organ. McLuhan's reading of Narcissus as narcosis makes every extension a sedative as much as an amplifier. Powered armor is extension; the Engine is the autoamputation that accompanies it. The suit amplifies Felix's body while the Engine numbs his self, and McLuhan explains why the two must arrive together: a body extended to the scale of the battlefield must be desensitized in proportion, or the stimuli it now gathers would overwhelm the organism that wears it.

2.3 THE CYBERNETIC ORGANISM AND THE BODY SCHEMA

The word *cyborg* was coined by Manfred Clynes and Nathan Kline in 1960, in a paper proposing that astronauts be modified into self-regulating systems whose homeostasis would be maintained automatically, leaving the person free to explore, create and feel. The proposal assumed that the organism's automatic functions could be delegated without loss to the person. *Armor* refutes that assumption under combat conditions. The suit handles life support, strength and mobility, but its most important automatism is not mechanical. It is the Engine, a self-regulating survival system that has migrated from the hardware into the man, and it does not free consciousness; it evicts it. The cybernetic program of Norbert Wiener's *Cybernetics* (1948), the unification of animal and machine under the logic of feedback, is fulfilled in Felix at the expense of the animal it was meant to serve.

Maurice Merleau-Ponty's *Phénoménologie de la perception* (1945) supplies the phenomenological complement. The blind man's cane, the feathered hat, the familiar car are incorporated into the body schema; their edges become the body's edges, and the subject inhabits them as a field of possible action, an "I can" prior to any "I think." Scout armor is incorporated in exactly this way, and Felix's competence after nineteen drops is motor intentionality of an extraordinary kind, a capacity to act that has outrun reflection. What Merleau-Ponty described as the body's lived intelligence becomes in Felix an intelligence lived by the suit-body while the person looks on.

2.4 STANDING-RESERVE AND ORGANIC CONSTRUCTION

Heidegger's lecture "Die Frage nach der Technik" (1954) named the modern technological disclosure of the world *Gestell*, enframing, which reveals everything, human beings included, as *Bestand*, standing-reserve held ready for use. Heidegger's thinking here was shaped by Ernst Jünger, whose essay "Die totale Mobilmachung" (1930) and treatise *Der Arbeiter* (1932) had described the conversion of whole societies into energies for war and the fusion of man and machine in an "organic construction." The Fleet of *Armor* is *Gestell* with a logistics department. Its soldiers are inventoried by survival odds (a veteran named Bolov tells Felix that a scout on his first drop has a ten percent chance of surviving), and its showpiece fort exists partly as a demonstration for visitors. The suit is the device that holds the reserve in readiness.

Jünger celebrated the man of steel as the type of the coming age. Klaus Theweleit's *Männerphantasien* (1977–78), reading the novels and memoirs of Freikorps men, analyzed the same figure as a psychic formation: the "soldier male" whose body armor (*Körperpanzer*) defends against the dissolving floods he associates with women and with the masses. The Freikorps were paramilitary units of First World War veterans that the German government used in 1919 to crush the Spartacist rising in Berlin and the Bavarian Soviet Republic; Freikorps officers murdered Rosa Luxemburg and Karl Liebknecht in January 1919, and many of their men later passed into the Nazi movement. Theweleit's point is that the armored body was the psychic precondition of that violence, above all of the violence, imagined and real, against women the men identified with communism. Behind Theweleit stands Wilhelm Reich's *Charakteranalyse* (1933), in which "character armor" names the chronic muscular and attitudinal rigidity that binds anxiety at the price of feeling. *Armor* knows both versions and refuses the first. Felix's armor does not announce a new type of man. It is the condition under which an old type, a grieving widower and an abdicated ruler, is kept alive against his will.

2.5 THE SHELL THAT IS ALSO A BOMB

The suit's most terrible property is disclosed early. On the mesa where the survivors of the first drop make their stand, a thermonuclear flash hurls Felix some twenty meters through the air. The ants, Forest tells him afterward, did not do this: someone keyed every relay of a warrior suit at once and then tried to eject, and any suit can do the same. Soldiers in armor, she says, are themselves atomic weapons, and no one is supposed to know it, since so spectacular an exit might prove impossible to resist. Forest dies soon afterward, confessing with her last words that she has always loved Nathan Kent, the Armored Olympics champion she had met in the finals. The armor that exists to keep its wearer alive contains the means of annihilating him and everyone near him. When the survivors resolve to destroy the Hive with a living bomb and their first choice is killed in an ambush, the mortally wounded Bolov accepts the role, and Felix's armored hands, which the novel at that moment assigns to the Engine rather than to Felix, fling him into the Hive.

These episodes expose the death drive housed inside the protective shield. Freud's *Reizschutz* buys life with partial death; the suit generalizes the bargain into a device whose outer layer can at any moment become an explosion. It is a shell and a warhead at once, and the soldier inside it is both the protected and the payload. Chapter 4 will show that this is precisely the logic of the insect colony the soldiers fight. Steakley's technical exoskeleton does not separate the human from the Ant. It is the hinge on which the human turns into one.



CHAPTER THREE

The Psychic Exoskeleton

The Engine as Cold Berserk

3.1 THE PHENOMENON

The Engine is introduced before it is explained, and it is never fully explained. Felix is a burned-out enlistee who will not die even when death seems certain, and when he enters combat a persona he calls the Engine takes over: a ruthless instrument devoted to keeping him alive at any cost. In the passage cited in the Introduction he describes it as an impersonal agency that will carry out, on his behalf, the whole sequence of examination, determination, choice and action, while the self he recognizes as his own cowers within.

The reader learns only later, from the recorder, why the paradox is so acute. Felix had been Guardian Archon of Golden, one of the two richest planets in known space, chosen from among twelve candidates. His wife Angel was an Earthwoman whom Golden's people never accepted; she slipped her guards, boarded a freighter, and died when it buckled, and it was Felix who found the ship and her body. He blamed Golden, ran from his office, and came to the war, as he later confesses to his oldest friend, wanting only to die. The novel opens with him drinking alone on the eve of his first drop, certain that everyone around him will die. The Engine is thus a survival apparatus installed in a man who enlisted in order not to survive.

Three features define the phenomenon. It is *impersonal*: Felix speaks of it in the third person, as an *It*. It is *executive*: it does not rage but calculates, and the faculties it exercises (perception, assessment, decision, motor control) are precisely those the psychological tradition assigned to the ego. And it is *mute*: the Engine acts but does not speak, and it has no story. Each feature calls for its own genealogy.

The novel frames the Engine as a question of identity from its first pages. In the passage cited in the Introduction, Felix disowns it in so many words: it is not he, he tells himself, but his Engine. The epigraph, attributed to the Masao, has already answered him: *You are / What you do / When it counts.* And on his last drop, telling his oldest friend that the Engine had been dying, Felix names its nature with a precision that anticipates the argument of this dissertation: it was, he says, "A what. As opposed to a who." Between the epigraph's ethic of deeds and Felix's disowning of his own deeds lies the whole problem of the psychic exoskeleton.

3.2 TOPOLOGY: THE SHIELD AND THE INVERTED DICTUM

Freud's *Jenseits des Lustprinzips* (1920) was written in the aftermath of the war neuroses of 1914–18, and its speculative biology of the protective shield was an attempt to explain why soldiers dreamed their traumas again and again. Trauma, on this account, is a breach of the *Reizschutz* by quantities of excitation the organism cannot bind, and the repetition compulsion is the psyche's belated attempt to master by repeating what it failed to anticipate. Felix's drops are a repetition compulsion with a military schedule: nineteen, then twenty, then twenty-one descents into the same catastrophe. The Engine is the shield's reply. Unable to prevent the breach, the psyche grows a second shield behind the first, a hardened layer that meets each repetition with pre-emptive deadness.

The Engine also reorganizes Freud's later topography. In *Das Ich und das Es* (1923) Freud took from Georg Groddeck the word *das Es*, "the It," for the impersonal reservoir of drive, and set over it an ego charged with perception, reality-testing and the control of motility. In the *Neue Folge der Vorlesungen* (1933) he condensed the therapeutic program into a famous formula: *Wo Es war, soll Ich werden*, "where It was, there I shall come to be." The Engine runs the formula backward. It is an *It*, impersonal and named as such, yet it does the ego's work, perceiving, judging and governing movement with a precision no ego commands. The *I*, meanwhile, is reduced to the very affect it was meant to master: fear, huddled in the interior. Felix's psyche obeys the inverse dictum, *Wo Ich war, soll Es werden*: where I was, there It shall be.

3.3 AUTOMATISM, DISSOCIATION, THE DIVIDED SELF

The clinical concept closest to the Engine predates Freud. Pierre Janet's *L'Automatisme psychologique* (1889) described how, under the shock of overwhelming events, the synthesizing activity of consciousness fails, and parts of mental life continue as automatisms: organized, competent, and split off from the personal synthesis. Contemporary trauma theory has reformulated Janet's *désagrégation* as the structural dissociation of the personali-

ty (Van der Hart, Nijenhuis and Steele 2006), in which an apparently normal part carries daily life while emotional parts, fixed in defensive action systems such as fight or freeze, carry the trauma. The Engine is a fight-system part of unusual sophistication, with one anomaly the theory helps to see: it is defensive yet affectless, a part whose emotion is the absence of emotion.

R. D. Laing's *The Divided Self* (1960) supplies the existential description. Laing's ontologically insecure person, threatened by engulfment, implosion and petrification, withdraws an "inner self" from the body and delegates transactions with the world to a "false-self system," which the inner self watches as if from outside, unembodied. Laing's case histories also explore a paradox of petrification, the dread of being turned from a person into a thing, an automaton, an impersonal it: one may defend against being made a thing by making oneself one first. Felix's Engine is a false self that has become better at living than the true self ever was, and the armor in which it operates is petrification chosen as protection against petrification.

Robert Jay Lifton contributed two terms that converge on the same structure. *Psychic numbing* (*Death in Life*, 1967) names the diminished capacity to feel that survivors develop against the death imprint. *Doubling* (*The Nazi Doctors*, 1986) names the formation of a second, functionally complete self that performs what the original self could not bear. Lifton developed the concept to explain the SS physicians of Auschwitz, men who selected arriving prisoners for the gas chambers and conducted experiments on inmates while remaining, in their own eyes, ordinary doctors and family men; he called the second self they formed an "Auschwitz self." Steakley's double belongs to a survivor who kills an alien enemy in war, and the moral situations are not comparable. What carries over is only the structure: a functional second self that does what the first cannot bear to do. The Engine is a double that does what Felix cannot, so that Felix can go on existing.

3.4 THE SECOND SKIN

Psychoanalysis has a precise name for an armor that holds a personality together when nothing else does. Esther Bick's "The Experience of the Skin in Early Object-Relations" (1968) described infants who, lacking an adequate containing object, form a "second skin": a muscular, hypertonic self-holding, often accompanied by pseudo-independence, which substitutes for the missing experience of being held. Didier Anzieu's *Le Moi-peau* (1985) generalized the insight into a theory of the ego as psychic envelope, with functions of maintaining, containing, shielding and inscribing traces. Felix's history renders Bick's model almost literal. The loss of Angel, one of the only two people who had ever truly touched him (the other is Allie), precedes the Engine. The Engine is the muscular second skin of a man whose container has died.

Jacques Lacan's essay on the mirror stage (1949) completes the genealogy at the level of the image. The infant, motorically uncoordinated and haunted by fantasies of the fragmented body, assumes its specular unity as *l'armure enfin assumée d'une identité aliénante*, the armor of an alienating identity, a rigid structure that marks its entire development. The same essay cites Roger Caillois's "Mimétisme et psychasthénie légendaire" (1935), which read the mimicry of insects as a temptation by space, an organism's loss of the boundary between itself and its milieu. The Engine joins both. It is an armor of alienated identity, and in combat it achieves a Caillois-like assimilation to its surroundings: it becomes the battlefield's own logic, a self dissolved into the space of killing.

3.5 THE COLD BERSERK

Jonathan Shay's *Achilles in Vietnam* (1994) gave the trauma literature its most influential reading of combat frenzy. Shay found in veterans' testimony a *berserk* state, triggered by the betrayal of "what's right" and by the death of a special comrade, and marked by rage, a sense of being godlike or beastlike, indifference to one's own safety, and atrocity. Its paradigm is Achilles after the death of Patroclus. The Engine shares the berserk's trigger structure (Felix's grief, the betrayals of command) and its dehumanization, but inverts every other term. It is cold where the berserk is hot. It calculates where the berserk rages. Above all, it is obsessed with the safety the berserk ignores: its whole purpose is that Felix should not die.

I propose to call it a *cold berserk*: a dissociative state of lucid, affectless hyper-competence organized around self-preservation rather than self-expenditure. The category is offered not only to literary criticism. It may name the shape of dissociative survival competence as clearly as Shay's term names the shape of rage, and it suggests why such states so often go unrecognized as injuries: they look like excellence.

The cold berserk has a prophet, and it is Jünger. In "Über den Schmerz" (1934) Jünger argued that modern man was developing a "second, colder consciousness," a capacity to regard himself as an object and to treat his own pain from outside, and that the photograph, standing outside the zone of sensibility, was its characteristic instrument. Jünger hailed this consciousness as the virtue of a coming age. *Armor* shows it as a wound, and in the battle recorder it also supplies the instrument.

Simone Weil's "L'Iliade ou le poème de la force" (1940) delivers the ethical verdict. Force, Weil wrote, turns anyone subjected to it into a thing, and it petrifies, differently but equally, the souls of those who suffer it and of those who wield it. The Engine is the wielder's thinghood. Felix survives by becoming the instrument of force and is thereby made a thing by the very power that saves him. Nietzsche had compressed the danger into a sentence: *Wer mit Ungeheuern kämpft, mag zusehn, dass er nicht dabei zum Unge-*

heuer wird (*Jenseits von Gut und Böse* §146). The monster Felix risks becoming is not a beast but a machine, and the abyss that gazes back is not the Ants' but his own.

3.6 THE LOOP AS PERSON

The sequence through which the Engine operates, perception passing into assessment, assessment into decision, decision into action, has an uncanny contemporary homologue. In the years of the novel's composition the U.S. Air Force strategist John Boyd was briefing American military reformers on what became known as the OODA loop: observe, orient, decide, act. Combat, on Boyd's account, is a contest of decision cycles, and victory goes to the side that cycles faster and so gets inside its opponent's loop. There is no evidence that Steakley knew Boyd's briefings, and none is required; the homology is the point. In the same years in which military theory was redefining the combatant as a decision cycle, Steakley imagined a soldier in whom that cycle had detached itself from the person and become a personality. The "human in the loop" of later debates on autonomous weapons has, in Felix, become the loop.

Two psychologies of excellence sharpen the diagnosis. Mihaly Csikszentmihalyi's research on *flow* (1975, 1990) described optimal experience as total absorption in an activity whose challenges match one's skills, with a loss of self-consciousness and a distortion of time. Hubert and Stuart Dreyfus's model of skill acquisition (1986) placed at its summit an expertise that no longer follows rules but responds intuitively and holistically, a coping in which deliberation falls silent. The Engine is both, and their dark double: flow without joy, expertise without an expert. It possesses everything the literature of excellence prizes except a self that could enjoy it.

3.7 THE SURVIVOR

Elias Canetti's *Masse und Macht* (1960) contains a chapter on the survivor that reads like a commentary on Felix. The moment of survival, Canetti argued, is the moment of power: horror at the sight of the dead turns into satisfaction that it is someone else who lies there. The hero is the one who has survived many times, and each survival thickens his sense of invulnerability. After nineteen drops Felix knows himself to be almost unstoppable, and the novel takes care that the knowledge brings him no satisfaction whatever. Steakley inverts Canetti's survivor as he inverts Shay's berserk: invulnerability is experienced not as power but as sentence.

What Felix carries instead is what Lifton called death guilt and what later clinicians named *moral injury*: the lasting wound left by perpetrating, failing to prevent, or witnessing acts that transgress one's deepest moral commitments (Litz et al. 2009). He out-

lives a company that is annihilated. With his own hands, under the Engine, he flings a dying comrade, who has accepted the role, into the Hive as a living bomb. He survives the missile strike that kills his oldest friend. The Engine protects the body from the war and leaves the conscience exposed to it, which is why its success is indistinguishable from damage.

3.8 ENGINE, INGENIUM, GENIUS

The Engine's name rewards etymology. English *engine* descends through Old French *engin*, which meant both skill and stratagem, from Latin *ingenium*, the inborn nature or talent of a person, itself from *in-* and *gignere*, "to beget." From the same root comes *genius*, in Roman religion the tutelary spirit born with each person and accompanying him through life. The Engine is Felix's *ingenium*: his native capacity, the thing in him he did not choose. It is also, as Old French *engin* recalls, a form of the practical, cunning intelligence the Greeks called *mētis* (Detienne and Vernant 1974), here stripped of speech. And it is his *genius* in the oldest sense, a companion spirit attached to him from without.

Hannah Arendt, in *The Human Condition* (1958), used the Greek counterpart of that spirit to make a point about identity. The "who" a person is, disclosed in action and speech, appears unmistakably to others yet may remain hidden from the person himself, like the *daimōn* of Greek religion that accompanies each man through life, looking over his shoulder from behind, visible only to those he meets. The Engine is Felix's daimon in exactly this sense. He cannot see it; he can only cower behind it. Chapter 5 will argue that the battle recorder is the device that makes the daimon visible to others, and Chapter 8 that this visibility is the condition on which Felix can at last become a who.



CHAPTER FOUR

The Swarm

The Ants, the Faceless Absolute, and the Myrmidonic Inversion

4.1 WHAT THE NOVEL WITHHOLDS

The Ants are three meters tall, insectile, innumerable, and silent. They live in Hives built into mountains; the thousand-meter crag called the Knuckle, objective of the first drop, proves to be one. They are not merely animals. They fire missiles from their Hives, they lock onto the Fleet's Transit beacons, and during the celebration that follows the successful defense of the human fort they attack from underground, killing dozens before they are crushed. They possess, in short, technique and tactics. What they do not possess, as far as the novel lets us know, is a face, a voice, an interior, a purpose, or a story. Steakley never grants them a point of view, never stages a parley, never explains the war's origin, and never hints at its end.

The withholding is the novel's most radical formal decision, and it should be read as such rather than as a failure of world-building. Every major predecessor and successor in the bug-war tradition eventually makes its insects mean something: communism for Heinlein, misunderstanding for Haldeman, tragic otherness for Card. Steakley's Ants mean nothing, and the meaninglessness is load-bearing. It is what makes the Antwar a pure case: violence with every mediating category removed.

4.2 RECOGNITION FORECLOSED

Hegel's *Phänomenologie des Geistes* (1807) derived self-consciousness from a struggle in which each party risks its life to be recognized by the other. The struggle ends not in death but in lordship and bondage, because a dead opponent can recognize no one; the dialectic requires that the vanquished survive to acknowledge the victor. Alexandre Kojève's lectures (published 1947) made this desire for recognition the motor of history it-

self. The Antwar is the struggle for recognition with its condition of possibility removed. The Ants cannot recognize and cannot be recognized; there is no prestige to be won from them and no submission to be accepted. Without recognition there can be no lordship and no bondage, only annihilation, and without the possibility of a vanquished survivor there can be no peace. The war cannot end because it has never begun in the Hegelian sense.

Emmanuel Levinas located the origin of ethics in the face of the other, whose nakedness and vulnerability utter, prior to any law, the command not to kill (*Totalité et infini*, 1961). The Ants have no face in this sense; nothing in their appearance addresses the soldier. But the novel's symmetry is exact, because the soldiers have no faces either. Encased in armor, they meet the Ants shell to shell. Wherever the novel stages recognition between persons (a dying confession of love, a friend's plea to come home, an adversary's sacrifice), it does so at the margins of combat, and its decisive act of recognition, Kent's, consists in breaking a shell open. The battlefield of *Armor* is a place from which the face has been abolished on both sides. Ethics, in Levinas's sense, has nowhere to occur there.

4.3 WAR WITHOUT THE POLITICAL

Carl Schmitt's *Der Begriff des Politischen* (1932) defined the political by the distinction between friend and enemy, the enemy being the existential other with whom combat, and the real possibility of physical killing, is conceivable. In *Theorie des Partisanen* (1963) he distinguished the conventional and the real enemy from the *absolute* enemy, and warned that absolute enmity, which arises when the enemy is stripped of humanity, ends only in annihilation. The Ants are absolute enemies not by ideological declaration but by ontology. Yet precisely because they are absolutely other, the friend-enemy distinction collapses into zoology. Schmitt's political presupposes that the enemy, however alien, could in principle become a party to a peace. The Antwar is enmity without the political.

Clausewitz's dictum that war is the continuation of politics by other means (*Vom Kriege*, 1832, I.1.24) has its corollary in his distinction between the abstract concept of "absolute war," an ascent to extremes, and the "real war" moderated by political purpose. The Antwar has no political purpose that the novel can name, and so it approaches the absolute; but it is also undramatic, logistical, endless, a war of attrition administered by officers more interested in demonstration than in victory. It is Clausewitz's absolute war with the sublimity removed and the bureaucracy left in.

Hannah Arendt insisted, in *On Revolution* (1963) and *On Violence* (1970), that violence is mute and that power arises only where human beings act and speak together. The Antwar is the purest instance of her distinction: violence without power, because there is no common world in which speech could pass between the parties. Elaine Scarry's *The*

Body in Pain (1985) adds the structural consequence. War, she argued, is a contest of injuring in which the reality of hurt bodies is lent to the disputed issues, so that the victor's beliefs acquire the incontestable reality of the wounds that decided them. In the Antwar there are no disputed issues for the bodies to substantiate. The wounds refer to nothing. This is why the Fleet must manufacture a referent: a showpiece fort, a public story, an audience of journalists and non-combatant officers. The official narrative of the Antwar is the meaning that the injuries themselves cannot supply.

4.4 THE INSECT SUBLIME

Edmund Burke's *Philosophical Enquiry* (1757) identified among the sources of the sublime an "artificial infinite": the succession of uniform parts, as in a colonnade, which gives the imagination no place to rest and so simulates the boundless. Kant's "mathematical sublime" (*Kritik der Urteilskraft*, 1790, §§25–27) relocated the experience to the failure of the imagination to comprehend a magnitude in a single intuition. The Ants are the artificial infinite of war. They are uniform, successive and inexhaustible; whatever is killed is replaced; the count can never be completed. The terror they inspire is not that of a particular monster but of number as such.

Elias Canetti described war as the meeting of two crowds, each seeking to convert the other into a heap of the dead. The Antwar is a double crowd with a fatal asymmetry. On one side stands a crowd in the strict sense, a mass whose members are interchangeable and apparently unafraid; on the other stand individuals in shells, each isolated in his armor, each counting his own survival. Felix's solitude in battle is the solitude of Canetti's survivor among the heaps.

4.5 THE TRADITION AND ITS REFUSALS

The comparative field clarifies what Steakley refuses. H. G. Wells's "The Empire of the Ants" (1905) imagined an Amazonian species with venom and something like technique, displacing humanity from a region of Brazil and, his narrator speculates, eventually from the world; *The First Men in the Moon* (1901) gave the Selenites a society in which each body is shaped from infancy to its function, a satire of specialization that anticipates the Engine's functional self. *Them!* (1954) made giant ants the progeny of the atomic test. Heinlein's Bugs, Haldeman's Taurans and Card's "buggers" are all, finally, legible: allegorical, misunderstood, or tragically other in a way that can be mourned.

The closest relative is not American but Polish. In Stanisław Lem's *Niezwyciężony* (*The Invincible*, 1964), a human cruiser on the planet Regis III is overmatched by swarms of tiny, insect-like machines, the product of a mechanical evolution that has selected for

nothing but persistence; the swarm is neither malevolent nor intelligent in any human sense, and the novel's hero concludes that not everything in the universe exists to be fought. Lem's *Solaris* (1961) had already made the failure of contact its subject. Steakley shares Lem's epistemological severity but denies its consolation. No institution in *Armor* withdraws in recognition of a limit. The war continues, and the only withdrawals are private ones, a desertion and an exile, whose lesson is carried home in the recorder.

4.6 THE SUPERORGANISM

The entomologist William Morton Wheeler proposed in 1911 that the ant colony is an organism, a "superorganism" in which individuals function as cells. Edward O. Wilson's *The Insect Societies* (1971) and Bert Hölldobler and Wilson's *The Ants* (1990) made eusociality a central problem of evolutionary biology. Douglas Hofstadter's dialogue "Ant Fugue," in *Gödel, Escher, Bach* (1979), gave the idea its philosophical form: an anteater converses with "Aunt Hillary," an ant colony whose mind exists only at the level of the whole, while no individual ant knows anything. If Steakley's Ants are something like this, then the war is a categorical mismatch. Individual heroism is aimed at individuals who do not matter, against a mind that exists nowhere in particular. Jussi Parikka's *Insect Media* (2010) has traced how such distributed, swarming intelligence became a model for media technologies themselves. The Ants of *Armor* belong to that genealogy: they are technique without a who.

The point returns us to the Engine. Hofstadter's colony thinks without any ant thinking; Felix's Engine acts without Felix acting. The subpersonal intelligence that the soldiers fight outside them is the same kind of intelligence that has colonized Felix from within.

4.7 THE MYRMIDONIC INVERSION

Ovid tells, in *Metamorphoses* 7, how Aeacus, king of Aegina, his people destroyed by plague, saw a column of ants climbing an oak and prayed for as many citizens; Jupiter turned the ants into men, whom Aeacus named Myrmidons after their origin (*myrmex*, "ant"). They kept, Ovid adds, the habits they had before: *parcum genus est patiensque laborum / quaesitique tenax* (7.655–656), a frugal race, enduring of toil, tenacious of what it has won. A fragment of the Hesiodic *Catalogue of Women* already knew the story. These ant-men were the soldiers whom Achilles led to Troy. The founding army of Western epic was, mythically, a colony of insects made human.

Armor runs the metamorphosis backward. Its armored infantry are Myrmidons in reverse: men turned into ants. They are workers, inventoried by survival odds, expended

without explanation. They acquire exoskeletons. Their dissociated combat selves resemble subpersonal routines more than persons. Most strikingly, they acquire the colony's ultimate defensive behavior. Certain ant species defend their nests by *autothysis*, the rupture of the worker's own body to spray its contents over attackers (Maschwitz and Maschwitz 1974; Laciny et al. 2018). The warrior suit overloaded on the mesa, every relay keyed at once, and Bolov flung into the Hive as a living bomb, are human autothysis. Even the fort reproduces the logic: humans build a fortified mound on Banshee, and the Ants strike it from underground, as if the Hive had entered it from below.

The planet's name completes the figure. *Banshee* is the Irish *bean sí*, the woman of the fairy mound, whose keening announces death; the mound, the *síd*, is the entrance to the Otherworld under the hill. The Ants' Hive inside a mountain is the *síd* of the novel, and the war is a perpetual descent into it. What the soldiers meet there is not an alien civilization but the shape of their own transformation. Nietzsche's abyss gazes back; the Myrmidons recognize, too late, the ants they were made from.



CHAPTER FIVE

The Mnemonic Exoskeleton

The Battle Recorder, Spectacle, and Testimony

5.1 THE DEVICE AND THE EXPERIMENT

The second half of *Armor* turns on an object. Aboard an abandoned sledcraft that Borglyn's pirates find grounded on a moon, the very craft Borglyn has promised Jack as payment, Jack comes upon a black scout suit in the drop bay and, on an impulse he later calls the most important act of his life, carries it off. When Borglyn orders it spaced, Jack has it saved and sent down with him in the lifeship as an offering for the project director, Hollis "Holly" Ware, a young genius whose favor he needs. Holly discovers that the suit's record has bled off its storage coil but survives in the suit itself, reachable only by routing its feeds into other helmets. So the immersion begins. Jack and Holly sit facing one another on twin loungers with helmets lowered over their heads, while Lya, Holly's partner, sits at a console between them, monitoring their vital signs, with deadman switches ready to pull them out. What they live through is rendered in Part Four, where the reader meets Felix as he sees himself and as he experiences battle.

The recorder is thus not a camera in the ordinary sense. It does not store what an observer could have seen; it stores what the wearer lived through, and it allows others to live through it again. Two immersants and a watcher, a trickster and a scientist inside the record and a woman keeping guard over their bodies, form a small tribunal of witness, embodying between them narrative, knowledge and care. What they find contradicts the war's official story. And what the finding does to them, Jack above all, is the hinge on which the novel's plot and its ethics turn.

5.2 TECHNOLOGICAL IMAGINARIES OF RECORDED EXPERIENCE

The recorder belongs to a cluster of contemporary inventions. Gibson's "simstim" (1984) lets one person ride the sensorium of another in real time. Douglas Trumbull's film *Brainstorm* (1983) imagined a device that records and replays sensation and emotion, and staged the recording of a death that others then experience. Kathryn Bigelow's *Strange Days* (1995) and the *Black Mirror* episode "The Entire History of You" (2011) carried the fantasy into the commerce and pathology of total recall. Within this genealogy, Steakley's version is distinguished by its institutional setting and its object. The recorder is a military instrument, closer to an aircraft's flight recorder than to an entertainment, and its contents are a single soldier's experience of a war the public has never been allowed to see.

Bernard Stiegler's *La Technique et le temps* (1994–2001) supplies the philosophical category. Extending Husserl's distinction between primary retention (the just-past held in the living present) and secondary retention (recollection), Stiegler named *tertiary retention* the exteriorization of memory in technical supports, from the notch and the alphabet to film and data, and argued that human temporality has always been constituted through such prostheses. The battle recorder is tertiary retention at its limit: memory carried not in the head but in the shell, an archive grown on the outside of the body.

Henri Bergson's *Matière et mémoire* (1896) indicates what such an archive can and cannot hold. Bergson distinguished habit-memory, the motor mechanisms acquired by repetition and expressed in action, from pure memory, which records each event in its singularity as an image. The recorder captures pure memory with superhuman fidelity. What it cannot capture is habit-memory, the sedimented competence of nineteen drops, because that competence does not exist as an image. The Engine lives in Bergson's first memory; the recorder holds the second. The secret of Felix's survival is therefore precisely what his recording cannot transmit.

5.3 SPECTACLE AND THE OFFICIAL STORY

Virilio's *Guerre et cinéma* argued that modern war is waged through a logistics of perception, in which the capacity to see, record and project has become as decisive as the capacity to destroy. *Armor* shows the logistics of perception operating at two scales. At the scale of the soldier, the suit is camera and weapon at once. At the scale of the institution, the Fleet stages the war for an audience. Felix learns from the fort's commander, Colonel Canada Shoen, that the liaison officers crowding its bunker have come to see combat from safety; he privately calls them tourists. Later he finds the main hall jammed with reporters for a press tour. The fort is what Daniel Boorstin, in *The Image* (1961), called a *pseudo-event*: an occurrence planned primarily in order to be reported, whose relation to

underlying reality is deliberately ambiguous. Its sequel, the Ants' underground assault on the celebrating garrison, is the reality the pseudo-event was designed to exclude.

The war has its sporting double. Forest and Nathan Kent have competed in a Fleet-wide Armored Olympics, a detail that recalls the ancient *hoplitodromos*, the race in armor introduced at Olympia in the late sixth century BCE, and Johan Huizinga's argument in *Homo Ludens* (1938) that war and play share the agonistic form of the contest. Kent, the champion, is known on sight across a dozen planets and called Everybody's Hero, the title of Part Four; his first drop, on the fort mission, is made amid aides, staff and the press corps. The war produces stars. Guy Debord's *La Société du spectacle* (1967) defined the spectacle not as a collection of images but as a social relation among people mediated by images. The official story of the Antwar is spectacle in Debord's sense: it organizes a whole society's relation to a war through images that conceal what the war is.

Susan Sontag's *On Photography* (1977) and *Regarding the Pain of Others* (2003) asked what images of suffering do to those who view them, and whether familiarity anesthetizes or obligates. Judith Butler's *Frames of War* (2009) relocated the question to the frame: what a war's representations include and exclude determines whose lives are perceived as lives and therefore as grievable. The recorder is a counter-frame. It does not show the Antwar as spectacle; it makes its viewers inhabit a single grievable life within it.

5.4 ERLEBNIS, ERFAHRUNG, AND THE PLANET CALLED SANCTION

Walter Benjamin provides the decisive framework. In "Erfahrung und Armut" (1933) and "Der Erzähler" (1936) he observed that the soldiers of 1914–18 came home not richer but poorer in communicable experience: a generation that had gone to school by horse-drawn tram found itself under an open sky in which nothing was unchanged but the clouds, and beneath them, in a field of destructive forces, the tiny, fragile human body. In "Über einige Motive bei Baudelaire" (1939) Benjamin explicitly took up Freud's *Reizschutz*. Consciousness, he argued, parries the shocks of modern life; a parried shock becomes *Erlebnis*, an isolated lived moment, at the expense of *Erfahrung*, experience integrated into tradition, memory and communicable wisdom.

The Engine is the perfect shock-parrying consciousness, and the recorder is the perfect archive of *Erlebnis*. Neither can produce *Erfahrung*. Felix does not tell his story; he could not. The recorder stores it as a sequence of shocks. Benjamin's storyteller needed a community of listeners, the slow evenings in which experience is passed from mouth to ear and woven into common life. The immersion sessions supply exactly this. Over successive sessions two people return to the same recording while a third keeps watch over them, and all three are changed. After the first session the witnesses begin to testify in their turn: Lya tells the story that gives Part Three its title. At ten, left to look after her

younger brother's puppy, she let it out alone, knowing, by her own bitter account, that it would fall into the deep well near the house. It fell, was badly hurt, and kept struggling in the water; after watching its agony, she killed it with stones. She had admired at first how it kept going like a little motor, and she insists through tears that it was no motor and no machine but a puppy. Jack sits frozen, silently begging her not to crack them open. In a book about a man who survives Banshee by becoming a motor, the parable needs little gloss: the novel sets beside Felix a creature whose machine-like persistence is not heroism but suffering, and a witness who had to decide what to do about it. The recorder becomes a storyteller only because a small community gathers around it to listen, and the listening cracks the listeners open.

Benjamin's essay contains a sentence that the novel's geography seems to have been built to answer. *Der Tod ist die Sanktion von allem, was der Erzähler berichten kann*: death is the sanction of everything the storyteller can tell; he has borrowed his authority from death. Felix's story is finally received, retold and acted upon on a planet named Sanction. Whether or not Steakley knew the sentence, the convergence is exact. The authority of the recording is borrowed from death, from Forest, Bolov, Allie, Kent and a company annihilated on the first drop, and the place where that authority is ratified is called by the very word Benjamin used for it.

5.5 KNOWING MORE THAN ONE CAN TELL

The recorder invites a further question. If it holds everything Felix lived through, could it teach what he knew? Michael Polanyi's *The Tacit Dimension* (1966) answered such questions in advance: we can know more than we can tell, and the knowing that matters most in skilled performance is subsidiary, embodied and unarticulated. Gilbert Ryle's distinction between knowing-how and knowing-that (*The Concept of Mind*, 1949), and Hubert Dreyfus's critique of formalized intelligence (*What Computers Can't Do*, 1972), made the same point against the ambitions of rule-based artificial intelligence.

Those ambitions were at their height when *Armor* was written. The early 1980s were the years of expert systems and of "knowledge engineering," the attempt to extract the competence of human experts and encode it as rules, and of Japan's Fifth Generation computing initiative (1982). Their characteristic obstacle, which Edward Feigenbaum's circle called the knowledge-acquisition bottleneck, was precisely that experts cannot say what they know. The recorder dramatizes the same limit from the other side. Total capture of experience does not yield competence. No one emerges from the immersions able to fight like Felix.

What the recorder transmits instead is conscience. The sessions force their participants to confront the gap between the public story of the war and its horror, and by the

end Jack, who came to sabotage the station, stands with Holly in its defense, under a plan that its own makers speak of as a suicide pact. The thief has become a defender. The recording teaches not how to survive but what is worth dying for. This is the novel's counter-wager to every program of extraction: recorded experience does not reproduce a skill, but it can reconstitute an ethos.

5.6 TESTIMONY AND THE VISIBLE DAIMON

Tim O'Brien's *The Things They Carried* (1990) distinguished "happening-truth" from "story-truth" and argued that the second can be truer than the first, because it transmits what it felt like rather than merely what occurred. The recorder seems to collapse the distinction by delivering happening-truth with the felt quality of story-truth intact. Yet the novel shows that even total capture requires interpretation: the trio must piece together who Felix was and what became of him, and the meaning of the recording is decided not inside it but in what its viewers do next.

Comparable figures clarify the stakes. Vonnegut's Tralfamadorians in *Slaughterhouse-Five* (1969) see all moments at once, as if life were a recording, and conclude that nothing can be changed. Gene Wolfe's *Soldier of the Mist* (1986) gives its amnesiac mercenary a scroll on which he must record each day, an exteriorized memory without which he would have no past. Christopher Nolan's *Memento* (2000) makes tattoos and photographs into a mnemonic exoskeleton for a man who cannot form new memories. Card's *Speaker for the Dead* (1986) makes the truthful telling of a dead person's life, neither excusing nor condemning, into a sacrament. *Armor* belongs with the last of these. The recorder becomes a speaker for a man presumed dead.

Arendt's daimon, introduced in Chapter 3, completes the account. The "who" of a person is visible to others but not to himself. The recorder is the device that places others behind Felix's shoulder: Jack and Holly, with Lya keeping watch over them, see his daimon, the Engine, from the position Arendt reserved for those who meet a person, while Felix himself could only cower behind it. That visibility is the first condition of his becoming a who rather than a what. The second, as Chapter 8 argues, is that someone must tell the story.

The novel's final image of Felix is itself a recording, and he destroys it. Jack and Holly follow the last battle on Borglyn's own feeds, at one point through a camera that looks over Borglyn's shoulder, the daimon's position in Arendt's figure, as Felix overruns the pirates' camp. Borglyn, terrified, lifts off and discharges every tactical weapon at once. Then the image from the ship's outer portside monitor comes clear: the black suit clings to the hull, one hand locked on a conduit, the other a fist driving at the camera's one eye, and the screen goes dark. The man who has been watched, recorded, re-lived and broad-

cast leaves the novel by putting out the eye that watches him. No one sees him die. When the representatives of Golden arrive and hear the story, they reply that their Archon was not seen to die, and they continue the search.

5.7 THE FIRST-PERSON ARCHIVE OF CONTEMPORARY WAR

In the forty years since the novel's publication, the battle recorder has ceased to be speculative. Helmet cameras, body cameras and first-person drone feeds have produced a vast archive of combat seen from inside the combatant's field of view. Islamic State fighters built propaganda videos from helmet-camera footage of their own assaults in Iraq and Syria in the mid-2010s. In Russia's war against Ukraine from 2022, units on both sides published footage from first-person-view drones guided onto enemy soldiers and vehicles, often set to music and circulated on Telegram and other platforms. Distant audiences watch, rate and share it. *Armor* anticipated both the archive and its ethical ambiguity. The same recording can be consumed as spectacle or received as testimony. Steakley's answer is unequivocal and demanding: watching is redeemed only when it obligates, when the viewer is changed by what he has lived through at second hand and acts accordingly. Jack watches, and then he stands.



CHAPTER SIX

The Social Exoskeleton

Jack Crow, Celebrity, and the Trickster's Gift

6.1 THE CELEBRITY PIRATE

The second strand of *Armor* begins abruptly, some time after the first, in the middle of a prison escape, and it is narrated in the first person. Jack Crow is a notorious celebrity and a former pirate: morally questionable, quick to kill, perpetually at odds with his own conscience, and acutely aware of the difference between his public reputation and the person he actually is. The reputation is often more burden than blessing. Escaping prison, he reaches the ship of Borglyn, a mutineer and deserter from the Antwar, and strikes a bargain: in return for his life, he will infiltrate and sabotage the Fleet's research project on Sanction so that Borglyn can tap its power source. The stated aim is a pretext; Borglyn intends to seize the planet. Jack is to be paid with an eight-man sledcraft of his own, its banks loaded with credits.

The contrast with the first strand is total, and deliberate. Felix is narrated in the third person; Jack narrates himself. Felix flees public identity, first as Golden's Guardian Archon and then as the reluctant hero of the Knuckle; Jack is little else. Felix's armor is welded to his nervous system by the Engine; Jack's armor is made of other people's perceptions. If Felix is the exoskeletal subject in its technical and psychic modes, Jack is its social mode: a self whose rigid outer layer is fame.

6.2 PERSONA AND THE PSEUDO-EVENT OF A PERSON

The Latin *persona* named the actor's mask. C. G. Jung adopted the word for the compromise between individual and society that a person presents to the world, a segment of the collective psyche mistaken for individuality, and warned against identification with it. Erving Goffman's *The Presentation of Self in Everyday Life* (1959) dissolved the opposi-

tion between mask and face into performance: front regions and back regions, teams and audiences, impressions managed in every encounter. Jean-Paul Sartre's *L'Être et le néant* (1943) had already given the performance its ethical name. His café waiter, playing at being a waiter, lives in *mauvaise foi*, bad faith, fleeing his freedom into the solidity of a role.

Jack Crow is a case study in all three, with a difference: he knows. His narration is a running negotiation between the legend and the man, and its irony is the irony of someone permanently backstage in his own life. Daniel Boorstin's *The Image* (1961) supplied the period's sharpest formula, defining the celebrity as a person known for being well known. Jack is, in Boorstin's other term, a pseudo-event in the shape of a person: an identity produced to be reported. The novel pairs him with the Fleet's pseudo-event in the shape of a fort. Both are social exoskeletons, and both are about to be breached by what the recorder holds.

6.3 THE TRICKSTER

Jack's lineage is older than celebrity. He belongs to the family of tricksters, the figures Paul Radin assembled in *The Trickster* (1956), with commentaries by Jung and Karl Kerényi, and that Lewis Hyde reinterpreted in *Trickster Makes This World* (1998) as boundary-crossers whose thefts and lies create culture. Odysseus is the Greek paradigm: *polytropos*, the man of many turns (*Odyssey* 1.1), who in disguise tells Athena, Eumaeus and Penelope a sequence of false tales in which he appears as a Cretan raider and adventurer (*Odyssey* 13, 14, 19). The pirate's biography is the trickster's favorite costume.

The Homeric *Hymn to Hermes* offers an even more exact emblem. On the day of his birth Hermes steals Apollo's cattle; on the same day he finds a tortoise, scoops out its flesh, and makes from its shell the first lyre. The trickster's founding act of culture is the conversion of an armored animal's shell into an instrument of song. That is precisely the transformation the second half of *Armor* performs. Jack Crow, thief and liar, carries the shell of a soldier presumed dead into a research station, and the shell becomes an instrument through which a life is sung.

6.4 ONOMASTICS: JACKDAW, CROW, MEMORY

The name is overdetermined. *Jackdaw*, the small thieving crow of European folklore, is formed from *jack* and *daw*; Jack Crow is a jackdaw by composition. Richard Harris Barham's "The Jackdaw of Rheims," in *The Ingoldsby Legends* (1840), tells of a jackdaw who steals a cardinal's ring, is cursed, repents, becomes a model of piety, and after his death is canonized under the name "Jem Crow," a pun on "Jim Crow," the blackface caricature of a Black man that the white performer Thomas Dartmouth Rice made famous

from about 1830, and whose name later became shorthand for the laws that enforced racial segregation in the American South. I do not suggest that Steakley meant the association; I record it because the name carries it, and it sits uneasily under the comic reading that follows. The comic hagiography of a thieving crow converted to sanctity is, in miniature, Jack Crow's arc in *Armor*: the thief who came to steal from the station is converted by what he finds there. In *Vampire$*, a Jack Crow will work for the Vatican itself.

Jack is also the English folk name of the giant-killer, the small, clever hero who defeats monsters by cunning rather than strength; the Ants are giants of a kind. And the crow is the bird of the battlefield. The Irish war goddess appears over slaughter as a crow, the *badb catha*. Odin's two ravens, Huginn and Muninn, Thought and Memory, fly over the world each day and return to tell him what they have seen; in *Grímnismál* (st. 20) the god confesses that he fears for Thought that it may not return, but fears more for Memory. Jack Crow is Muninn: the bird who flies over a battlefield he never fought on and returns bearing its memory. The trickster's vocation, in Steakley's version, is mnemonic.

6.5 THE TROJAN HORSE

Odysseus' most famous stratagem was a hollow armored body. Demodocus sings in *Odyssey* 8 of the wooden horse that Odysseus brought into Troy as a ruse, filled with men; in *Aeneid* 2 Laocoön warns the Trojans to fear the Greeks even when they bring gifts (*timeo Danaos et dona ferentes*, 2.49). Jack's gift of the old armor to Holly is a Trojan horse in exact structural terms: a hollow shell carried into the citadel as a pretext for access, by a trickster acting for an invading force.

Steakley's variation lies in what comes out of the horse. It is not soldiers but memory, and it conquers not the city but the man who brought it. The ruse turns on the trickster: the gift he offered in bad faith becomes the instrument of his conversion. There is a second reversal, held back until the end. The real armored man was already inside the city, hidden under another name, and he emerges from concealment only when the city is about to fall. The Trojan horse of *Armor* is double: an empty shell that carries a life into the citadel, and a living man who has been waiting there without his shell.

6.6 CONTEMPT AND ANAGNORISIS

Throughout the Sanction narrative Jack encounters Lewis, who owns the whole planet and governs it with almost no law: one of the few forbids weapons, and his standing policy permits no private blazers. Jack dismisses him as a lightweight drunk and can scarcely believe that this is the owner and master of everything in sight. The novel plants clues he cannot read: Lewis steps smoothly out of range of a drunk's haymaker without ceasing to

laugh, and he tells the besieged project that he would rather give the planet away than see Holly killed. At the climax Lewis appears in the Dome and is revealed as Felix. The abandoned sledcraft in which Jack found the suit had carried Felix to Sanction; Holly, it emerges, has kept the suit fully operational; and Felix, having explained that Kent saved him and that Fleet cut Kent in half for it, lies down in the suit, which closes over him.

Aristotle's *Poetics* (1452a) held that the finest recognition, *anagnōrisis*, coincides with reversal, *peripeteia*, as in the *Oedipus*. *Armor*'s recognition meets that standard and adds a moral edge. Jack's contempt has been directed, throughout, at the man whose memory he has been living. He has been moved by Felix in the recorder while sneering at Felix in the flesh, and at the moment of recognition the narration itself fuses the two names. The scene indicts the trickster's eye, which reads people by their shells and mistakes the soft for the worthless, and it indicts the reader, who has shared Jack's narration and therefore his contempt. The hard-bodied culture of the decade, in Jeffords's terms, could not recognize its hero once he had taken off his armor.

6.7 THE DYAD BEYOND ARMOR

Steakley's second novel suggests that the pair meant more to him than a single plot required. *Vampire$* (1990) makes Jack Crow the ex-DEA leader of a commercial vampire-hunting company secretly backed by the Catholic Church, and Felix a gifted gunman, a former drug-runner who owns a bar called the Antwar Saloon. The copyright page carries a disclaimer: "This Felix is no other Felix. This Jack Crow is no other Jack Crow." The denial confirms what it denies. In both books Jack is the wisecracking, compromised almost-hero and Felix the gifted, reluctant warrior; in both, their roles cross. In *Armor* Felix vanishes and Jack settles into a new life. In the later novel Jack, defeated and suicidal, is taken by the vampires, and Felix assumes the leadership of the team. The Crow-Felix dyad is Steakley's portable myth, a talker and a doer bound together, each completing the other by changing places with him. Chapter 7 gives that myth its ancient name.

CHAPTER SEVEN

The Judgment of Arms

Ajax, Odysseus, and the Chiasmus of the Two Strands

7.1 THE ANCIENT CONTEST

After the death of Achilles, the Greek tradition tells, his arms were offered to the best of the surviving Achaeans, and two claimants came forward: Ajax son of Telamon, the giant of endurance who had carried Achilles' body from the field, and Odysseus, the master of stratagem who had covered its retreat. The *hoplōn krisis*, the judgment of arms, was narrated in the lost *Little Iliad*, whose outline survives in Proclus' summary of the Epic Cycle. Odysseus won. Ajax went mad, slaughtered the army's herds believing them to be his enemies, and on recovering his senses killed himself.

The episode became one of antiquity's great arguments about value. In *Odyssey* 11 Ajax's shade, still angry over the verdict, refuses to answer Odysseus' conciliatory words and turns away into the dark; the treatise *On the Sublime* would call that silence greater than any speech. Pindar twice protested the verdict (*Nemean* 7 and 8): he suspected that Homer's sweet words had made Odysseus' story greater than his sufferings, and he blamed envy and secret ballots for Ajax's defeat. Sophocles' *Ajax* staged the madness, the shame and the suicide, and gave Odysseus the play's moral turn: confronted with his enemy's ruin, he pities him, recognizing that all who live are phantoms or a weightless shadow (*εἴδωλ' ὅσοιπερ ζῶμεν ἢ κούφην σκιάν*, 126). Antisthenes composed a pair of declamations, *Ajax* and *Odysseus*, in which the warrior defends deeds done in the open and the strategist defends covert work done alone. Ovid's *Metamorphoses* 13 turned the contest into a formal debate, whose opening the second epigraph of this dissertation quotes: as much as Ajax prevails in war, so much does his rival prevail in speech.

The question beneath all these versions is the question beneath *Armor*: who inherits the arms, the one who acted or the one who can speak? Which is to ask, who owns the meaning of violence?

7.2 FELIX AS AJAX

Felix's temperament is Ajacian in every particular. Ajax is the *herkos Achaiōn*, the bulwark of the Achaeans (*Iliad* 3.229), defined by his immense shield "like a tower" (7.219), which Ovid compresses into an epithet, *clipei dominus septemplicis*, master of the sevenfold shield (*Met.* 13.2). He endures where others flee. He speaks little. Felix, likewise, endures; he seeks no distinction and courts no notice, and his identity is inseparable from his armor. Ajax's madness, a state in which he kills with full competence while mistaken about everything that matters, is the mythic prototype of the dissociated combat state that Chapter 3 named the cold berserk. Ajax's suicide shadows Felix's enlistment, undertaken in order to die. And Ajax's silence in the underworld is Felix's silence in the novel: he never tells his own story; it is recorded, reconstructed and told by others.

One detail complicates the identification. Felix is a *scout*, and in the Homeric world scouting belonged to Odysseus, who with Diomedes undertakes the night reconnaissance of *Iliad* 10, and whom Antisthenes makes boast of entering the enemy's city alone and in disguise to spy. Felix thus combines Ajax's temperament with Odysseus' function. As Chapter 2 noted, the scout is etymologically the listener. He is an Odyssean figure who has never acquired an Odyssean voice.

7.3 JACK CROW AS ODYSSEUS

Jack Crow is Odysseus in voice. He is the pirate of the Cretan tales, the deviser of a gift that is a stratagem, and above all a first-person narrator of his own adventures, as Odysseus is in the *Apologoi* of *Odyssey* 9–12, where King Alcinous praises him for telling his tale with the skill of a bard (11.368). Jack's narration has the same double edge as Odysseus': it is charming, self-aware and unreliable, and it is the instrument by which a reputation is made and managed.

But the novel does not leave him there. Changed by the recorder, the trickster chooses an almost certainly suicidal stand against Borglyn's assault. He assumes, that is, the Ajacian posture: the bulwark who holds his ground when holding is hopeless. The speaker learns to stand.

7.4 THE CHIASMUS, AND PLATO'S CHOICE OF LIVES

The structure that results is a chiasmus, and its key lies in the last pages of Plato's *Republic*. In the Myth of Er (10.614b–621d), a soldier killed in battle revives on his funeral pyre to report what he saw in the other world, where the souls of the dead choose their next lives. The twentieth soul to choose, Er reports, was that of Ajax son of Telamon, who chose the life of a lion, refusing to become a man again because he remembered the judgment of the arms (*μεμνημένην τῆς τῶν ὅπλων κρίσεως*, 620b). The soul of Odysseus drew the last lot of all. Cured of the love of honor by the memory of its former toils, it went about for a long time looking for the life of a private man who minds his own affairs, *βίον ἀνδρὸς ἰδιώτου ἀπράγμονος*, found it lying neglected by the others, and chose it gladly, saying it would have done the same had it drawn the first lot (620c–d).

Plato's myth distributes the two heroes' afterlives along exactly the axis *Armor* explores. Ajax chooses the beast, a life of force without humanity. Odysseus chooses obscurity, a life without public action. Felix, remarkably, lives both. The Engine is Ajax's lion: force divested of the human. Lewis the rancher is Odysseus' choice: the private man on a remote planet, minding his own affairs, disarming his neighbors, drinking. Jack moves the other way, from the polytropic life of the trickster through Ajax's stand to a settled life on Sanction beyond the Fleet's reach. The two men exchange places, and the novel's double plot, two strands that cross at the moment of recognition, is that exchange given narrative form. A numerical rhyme may be recorded without being leaned upon: Plato's Ajax drew the twentieth lot, and Felix's twentieth drop is the one on which he joins the building of the fort, the Fleet's showcase, where his disgust with the war's staging begins. The coincidence is too exact to omit and too slight to bear weight.

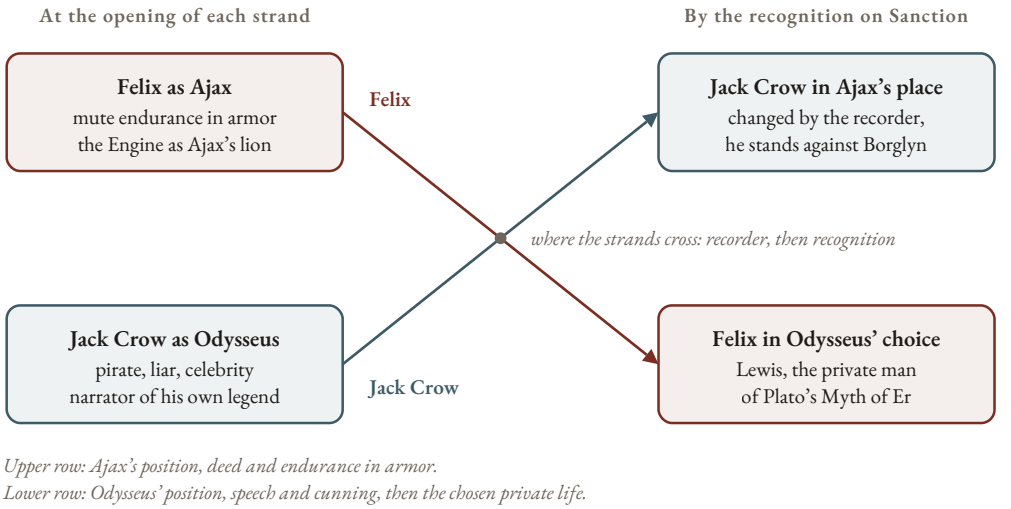


FIGURE 2 *The chiasmus of the two strands.* Each strand ends in the position from which the other began. The armor itself then passes back to Felix, who re-arms for others and vanishes, while Jack, Holly and Lya remain on Sanction.

The last scene seals the exchange with a Homeric signature. The most famous deed of Odysseus is the blinding of the Cyclops, the one-eyed giant who devours his men, to whom he had given his name as Nobody (*Odyssey* 9). Felix, who has lived on Sanction as a nobody called Lewis, ends the novel by driving his fist into the single eye of the camera through which Borglyn, and Jack and Holly, are watching him. The silent warrior closes the book with the trickster's signature act, and the man who has been nothing but an image puts out the eye that made him one.

7.5 THE ITINERARY OF THE ARMS

Igor Kopytoff proposed that objects have biographies, careers through which they pass between persons, regimes of value and meanings ("The Cultural Biography of Things," 1986). The armor's biography is the novel's hidden plot. It is Felix's suit, and it carries him through his drops on Banshee. Nathan Kent pops it open and puts Felix aboard the ship that Allie, Felix's oldest friend, had brought to take him home. Felix reaches Sanction and abandons the ship, which drifts until its scanners set it down on a moon; there Borglyn's pirates find it, the suit still in its drop bay, and Borglyn promises the craft to Jack. Jack takes the suit, saves it from being spaced, and gives it to Holly, who opens its record to two immersants and a watcher and quietly restores it to working order. Then Felix puts it on again, and it leaves the human world with him.

Every transfer in that chain is a gift, and most are gifts of life. Allie gives a ship and funds; Kent gives escape at the cost of his own life; Jack gives the suit in bad faith; the recorder gives memory; Holly gives the suit back its power; Felix gives rescue. Marcel Mauss's *Essai sur le don* (1925) described the obligations to give, to receive and to reciprocate, and reported the Maori notion of the *hau*, the spirit of the gift, which seeks to return to its place of origin. Lewis Hyde's *The Gift* (1983) added that a gift must keep moving or it dies. The armor obeys both laws. It circulates until it returns to its origin, and then it vanishes. The judgment of arms is resolved not by a verdict, which would make the arms someone's property, but by a gift economy in which the arms belong to no one.

7.6 PATROCLUS REVERSED

The *Iliad* contains a second story about borrowed armor. Patroclus, wearing Achilles' arms, is killed by Hector, who strips them from his body (*Iliad* 16–17); Antilochus brings the news, and Achilles' grief erupts (18.1–21). Kent's story inverts the pattern twice. When Felix tells him of Forest's death and of her love for him, Kent's grief erupts as drunken violence against the messenger. Later, after the Hammer, the Ants' missile barrage homing on the Transit beacon, kills Allie, Kent comes at Felix with the same iron look, drives a fist into his faceplate, pops his suit open, puts him aboard Allie's ship, and is cut in half by Fleet troops while blocking their way. Patroclus died by putting on the hero's armor in the hero's place. Kent dies by taking the hero's armor off, so that the hero may live as something other than a soldier. The Patroclean substitution, death in borrowed shells, becomes the novel's founding act of liberation from shells.

7.7 GOLD, BRONZE, AND THE BLESSED

Felix's prehistory adds a cosmological frame. He was the Guardian Archon of a planet called Golden, and the title fuses the two words Plato used for the rulers of the just city, *phylakes* and *archontes*. In the Republic's "noble lie," the Myth of the Metals (3.414b–415d), the god who formed the citizens mixed gold into the rulers, silver into the auxiliaries who fight, and bronze and iron into the farmers and craftsmen. Felix descends through all three classes. He is a gold-souled ruler of Golden, then a soldier, then a rancher. His trajectory is a katabasis of the philosopher-king, a refusal of Plato's demand that the one who has seen the light return to rule.

Hesiod's myth of the races (*Works and Days* 109–201) supplies the other metallic scale. The bronze race had arms of bronze and houses of bronze and worked in bronze, for black iron did not yet exist (*τοῖς δ' ἦν χάλκεα μὲν τεύχεα, χάλκεοι δέ τε οἶκοι*, 150), and its men destroyed one another. After them came the heroes who fought at Thebes and

Troy. Some of them died; to others Zeus granted a life apart at the ends of the earth, on the Isles of the Blessed, where they dwell as *ὄλβιοι ἥρωες*, happy heroes (172). Latin renders *olbios* as *felix*. Felix's end is the heroic translation. No one sees him die, and the representatives of Golden, holding that their Archon was not seen to die, continue the search. He passes out of the world as Achilles was carried to the White Island, as Menelaus was sent to Elysium (*Odyssey* 4.561–569), as Arthur went to Avalon, *rex quondam rexque futurus*, and as Sebastian of Portugal vanished at Alcácer Quibir, leaving a people to await his return.

The alias under which he hid completes the irony. *Lewis*, like *Louis* and *Ludwig*, derives from the Frankish *Hlūdawīg*, "famous in battle." The anti-war drunk who permits no private blazers on his planet has named himself, in a dead language, a renowned warrior. The social exoskeleton he chose to hide in carries, encrypted, the confession it was designed to suppress.

7.8 PINDAR'S PROTEST AND STEAKLEY'S VERDICT

Pindar's complaint against Homer was that eloquence had overpaid Odysseus: art had made his story greater than his sufferings, while Ajax's sufferings went unsung. *Armor* answers the complaint by inverting it. Here the sufferings of the silent warrior are preserved without art, in a recording that cannot flatter, and the eloquent man's gift is placed in their service. The trickster becomes the witness; the speaker is subordinated to the deed; and the deed, released from the obligation to be heroic, is permitted to become private.

Steakley's verdict in the ancient case, then, is neither Ajax nor Odysseus. The arms go to no one. The speaker must become a witness, the doer must be allowed to become a private man, and the armor must be given rather than won. Sophocles' Odysseus, looking at the ruined Ajax and seeing in him the shadow that all the living are, had already glimpsed the ethic that follows. Chapter 8 names it.



CHAPTER EIGHT

Ecdysis

Toward an Ethics of the Teneral

8.1 THE BIOLOGY OF THE MOLT

An arthropod cannot grow inside its armor. To increase in size it must pass through a sequence that entomologists divide into stages. In *apolysis* the old cuticle separates from the living epidermis beneath it, and a new, soft cuticle is secreted underneath. In *ecdysis* proper, triggered by the molting hormone ecdysone, the animal splits the old shell and climbs out of it. There follows the *teneral* stage, from Latin *tener*, "soft, tender": the newly molted creature is pale, soft-bodied, often unable to fly or fight, and acutely exposed to predation. Only afterward does *sclerotization*, the chemical tanning of the new cuticle, harden it into armor again.

Three features of this process carry the argument of this chapter. Growth requires the molt; an arthropod that never sheds its shell never becomes larger than it was. The molt is the most dangerous hour of the animal's life; the price of growth is a period without defenses. And the new armor is not the old one; the creature that hardens again is not the creature that shed. Exoskeletal subjectivity, read through its own biological figure, implies its own ethics. If the self of *Armor* is exoskeletal, its moral life can only consist in molting.

8.2 NO ONE MOLTS ALONE

The novel's decisive ethical event is a molt performed by another, though it is prepared from within. On his last drop Felix tells Allie that the Engine had already been dying and that he was on his way back before his friend arrived. Then the Hammer, the Ants' missile barrage homing on the Transit beacon, kills Allie, and aboard the Terra, Nathan Kent, who had wept and then raged when Felix told him of Forest's love and death, comes at him with the same iron look, drives a fist into his faceplate, and pops his suit

open; the recording goes blank at that instant. Kent puts him aboard Allie's ship and is cut in half by Fleet troops while blocking their way. Every element of the scene is significant. The shell is opened from outside, by force, by someone who has reason to hate the man inside it. The opening costs the opener his life. And the man extracted from the shell is not freed into strength: he falls, relaxes, lets go, and is sent away soft and unarmed.

D. W. Winnicott called the environment that makes a fragile self possible a *holding* environment ("The Theory of the Parent-Infant Relationship," 1960). Esther Bick showed that where holding fails, the infant manufactures a second skin to hold itself (Chapter 3). Kent's act is a holding of the most violent kind. It provides, in a single gesture, what Felix's second skin had replaced: the experience of being held by another, at a cost the other bears. The ethical lesson is structural before it is moral. The exoskeletal subject cannot molt by itself, because the shell is precisely what has taken the place of others. Someone must come from outside and open it.

8.3 THE TENERAL LIFE AND ITS PATHOLOGIES

What follows the molt is not redemption but Lewis. The deserter becomes the alcoholic owner of a remote planet, a man so profoundly opposed to war that one of his few laws forbids weapons and his standing policy permits no private blazers, and so visibly irresponsible that Jack Crow, who has spent the novel coming to honor Felix through the recorder, despises him. Steakley refuses to romanticize the unarmored state. The teneral creature, exposed and unable to bear its exposure, improvises substitute shells from whatever is at hand.

There are three such shells. The first is chemical: alcohol, which numbs as the Engine numbed. Edward Khantzian's "self-medication hypothesis" (1985) argued that addictive substances are chosen for their specific power to relieve intolerable affective states, and Lewis's drinking is the Engine's narcosis by other means. Nor is it new: the novel's first sentence finds Felix drinking alone on the eve of his first drop. Alcohol is the oldest of his shells, older than the Engine. The second is political: the ban on weapons, an exoskeleton imposed on an entire planet, a law designed to guarantee that no one on Sanction will ever need an Engine. The third is social: the alias, whose etymology, as Chapter 7 showed, encrypts the warrior it was chosen to hide. The teneral is not innocence. It is a condition of danger and of temptation to re-armor in degraded forms, and the novel shows it with clinical candor.

The planet's name is apposite. Latin *sanctio* named a decree and the penalty attached to it; *sancire* meant to make sacred and inviolable. A sanction is both a permission and a punishment. Sanction is the place where Felix's violence is forbidden, by his own law, and the place where it is finally authorized, by necessity, and paid for.

8.4 RE-ARMORING AS GIFT

The climax tests the teneral ethic at its hardest point. Borglyn's forces are on the verge of overrunning the research station; Jack and Holly are about to be killed. Lewis appears in the Dome and is revealed as Felix. Holly has kept the old suit fully operational. Felix lies down in it, it closes over him, and the two of them stand up together, a sight Jack finds terrifying. The suit hurts, Felix says; he is out of shape. Then he goes out alone, overruns the pirates' camp, and runs down Borglyn's ship as it lifts. Borglyn discharges every tactical weapon at once and flees into the sky. Felix is last seen through the ship's outer monitor, clinging to the hull, his free hand a fist driving at the camera's eye; then the screen goes dark.

The scene does not repudiate armor. It distinguishes between two uses of it. The Engine was armor for the self, a mechanism dedicated to keeping Felix alive at any cost. The final battle is armor for others: the shell resumed not to survive but to save, at the probable cost of the wearer's life. The difference is not in the steel but in the direction of the gift. The teneral ethic does not forbid shells. It holds that a shell is ethical only when it is assumed for others, and only for the hour. The novel marks the symmetry with a gesture used twice. Part Four ends when Kent's fist strikes Felix's faceplate and the recording goes dark; Part Five ends when Felix's fist strikes the camera and the screen goes dark. The blow that once freed Felix from his shell returns as the blow that frees him from the eyes upon him.

The plant that shares the project director's name offers an emblem. The common holly is heterophyllous: on the lower branches, within reach of browsing animals, its leaves are armed with spines, while higher up, beyond reach, they are often smooth. Holly arms itself where it is threatened and nowhere else. Arthur Schopenhauer's parable of the porcupines (*Parerga und Paralipomena* II, 1851, §396) makes the same point about human beings: driven together by the cold and apart by each other's quills, they settle at a moderate distance. *Neon Genesis Evangelion* (1995–96) borrowed the parable as an episode title, made the psychic barrier between persons into a literal force field, and then imagined its abolition in a project that would dissolve every individual into a single collective sea; its adolescent pilot, at the end, refuses the merger and chooses separate, painful, vulnerable existence. George R. R. Martin's "A Song for Lya" (1974) had staged the same temptation: its telepathic heroine abandons her lover to join an alien communion that promises an end to the loneliness of individuals. Steakley's Lya, who keeps watch over other people's interiors from her console, remains an individual. The teneral ethic refuses the shell and the hive alike. It chooses the dangerous middle condition: separate, soft, and held.

8.5 THE NARRATABLE SELF

Arendt held that action reveals *who* someone is, as distinct from *what* he is (his qualities, talents and shortcomings), and that this "who" can be grasped only in the story that others tell after the fact. At the head of her chapter on action she placed Isak Dinesen's remark that sorrows become bearable when they are put into a story. Adriana Cavarero's *Tu che mi guardi, tu che mi racconti* (1997; *Relating Narratives*, 2000) developed the thought into an ethics. Every unique existent, Cavarero argued, desires to hear its own story told by another; the self is not a substance but a narratable life, and its identity is entrusted to those who tell it. She opened her book with a parable from Karen Blixen's *Out of Africa* (1937): a man wakes in the night to a noise, runs back and forth around his pond, stumbling and falling as he stops the leaks, and in the morning sees from his window that his footprints have drawn the figure of a stork. The design of a life is visible only from outside, and only afterward.

Armor is built on that parable. Felix's drops are footprints made in the dark, frantic, repetitive, falling and rising. He cannot see their figure. It becomes visible only to others, after the fact, through the recorder, and the novel's very grammar enacts the transfer. Felix is narrated in the third person, by others. In the immersion sessions he is lived by others. Jack, who narrates himself, is the novel's unreliable "what": a reputation telling its own legend. The "who" belongs to the man who cannot tell his story and must have it told. Felix becomes a who, at last, not when he survives but when he is witnessed. He has named the distinction himself: the Engine, he tells Allie on his last drop, was "A what. As opposed to a who." The recorder made his daimon visible; the trio's witness gives it a story; Jack's stand, and the community that survives it, give the story an ending.

8.6 PRECARIOUSNESS AND THE EXPOSED SKIN

Judith Butler's *Precarious Life* (2004) argued that bodily vulnerability is a condition shared by all and that the politics of war depends on distributing grievability unequally, so that some lives are perceived as lives and others are not. Emmanuel Levinas, in *Autrement qu'être* (1974), described the ethical subject not as a sovereign self but as exposure: a sensibility offered to the other, vulnerable to wounding and outrage, a skin with nothing behind it to retreat into. Levinas's subject is, biologically speaking, teneral. Butler's precariousness is the condition of the molt generalized to everyone.

Armor gives both thinkers a narrative body. The Antwar distributes grievability by fiat: the Ants are ungrievable by construction, and the soldiers almost as much, inventoried by survival odds and staged for journalists. The recorder restores grievability to one

life. And the novel's ending refuses the exoskeletal answer to precariousness, which is to armor oneself absolutely, in favor of the teneral answer, which is to hold and be held.

8.7 THE TENERAL COMMUNITY

The epilogue is quiet. No one has found Borglyn's ship, though Jack and Holly looked. The people of Golden arrived a month after the battle, heard the story, and declined to abandon the search for an Archon who had not been seen to die; they still stop by. Sanction has left the Fleet entirely. It has a growing colony and a government, and Jack and Holly sit on a Council of Elders that seldom calls on them. Lya, mother of Holly's daughter, is pregnant again. Jack and Karen are still together and, he insists, not happy, and Jack himself is growing fat and thoughtful. The novel's final social form is small, unarmored and unheroic: a seceded colony of births and middling marriages, founded by people who were changed by living through another man's life.

The contrast with the novel's other collectives is exact. The Fleet is a shell for producing shells. The Ants are a hive without faces. Golden was a society that never accepted the Earthwoman its Guardian married; in Felix's bitter account its guards did not care enough to keep her safe, and it lost its leader. The colony on Sanction is the only collective in the novel that is neither armored nor merged. It is the teneral community: a few soft creatures holding one another in the interval before the next hardening, and choosing to keep the interval open.

8.8 THE TENERAL ETHIC

The ethic that *Armor* proposes can now be stated in four propositions.

I. **The self is not its shell.** Technical, psychic, mnemonic and social exoskeletons preserve life by mortifying part of it, and a self that identifies with any of them has mistaken its protection for its being.

II. **Shells are held in trust.** Armor is not evil, but it is ethical only as a gift: assumed for others rather than for self, and only for the hour that requires it.

III. **No one molts alone.** Growth, testimony and love occur in the soft interval between shells, and the interval is survivable only if others hold it open, sometimes at great cost to themselves.

IV. **A life becomes a who when it is narrated by another.** Witness is the community's form of holding, and the archive becomes a story only where people gather to receive it and are changed.

The ethic positions the novel against two powerful contemporaries. Against Heinlein's civic militarism, in which hardness earned in service is the ground of citizenship, it holds that hardness is a wound to be outgrown, however necessary its hour. Against the posthumanist celebration of the cyborg, in which fusion with machines promises emancipation from the limits of the human, it holds that the most important human capacity is not augmentation but exposure. Nor does it return to the endoskeletal interior of the humanist tradition, the inner citadel of truth that Augustine invited us to enter. The teneral ethic belongs neither to the shell nor to the core. It is an ethics of the interval: of the soft hour in which a creature that has left one armor has not yet grown another, and in which, for that reason alone, it can grow.



CONCLUSION

The Soft Hour

FINDINGS

This dissertation has argued that John Steakley's *Armor* is a sustained anatomy of exoskeletal subjectivity, and that its apparent simplicity as a military adventure conceals an architecture of considerable philosophical precision. Six findings may be restated. First, the novel's titular figure is plural: a technical, a psychic, a mnemonic and a social exoskeleton, nested and each governed by the Freudian law of the protective shield, which preserves life by mortifying part of it. Second, the Engine is a *cold berserk*, an executive automatism that inverts Freud's dictum and installs the military-cybernetic decision loop as a personality; it is distinguishable from the hot berserk of the trauma literature by its lucidity, its affectlessness and its devotion to the very survival the berserk squanders. Third, the Ants are the *faceless absolute*, an enemy outside recognition, the face, the political and speech, and the war against them effects a *Myrmidonic inversion* in which men become the insects they fight. Fourth, the battle recorder is a mnemonic exoskeleton that stores *Erlebnis* without *Erfahrung*; it is redeemed only by a community of witness, and what it transmits is conscience rather than competence. Fifth, the double plot restages the ancient judgment of arms between doer and speaker and resolves it by chiasmus and by gift: the arms belong to no one. Sixth, the novel's ethical center is *ecdysis*, the molt, performed for Felix by another at the cost of a life, and the ethic it implies is a *teneral ethic* of the interval between shells.

IMPLICATIONS

For the history of science fiction, the argument identifies a counter-tradition within military SF that might be called the line of the shell. Its texts take powered armor, repetition and hidden identity not as instruments of triumph but as problems of personhood. Iain M. Banks's *Use of Weapons* (1990) braids two chronologies toward the revelation that its

mercenary hero has been living under another man's name. Hiroshi Sakurazaka's *All You Need Is Kill* (2004), filmed as *Edge of Tomorrow* (2014), turns a soldier in a powered suit into an Engine through the repetition of his own death. Haldeman's *Forever Peace* (1997) imagines remotely operated war machines whose operators are humanized, against all military intention, by prolonged linkage with one another. *Neon Genesis Evangelion* makes the boundary of the self into the decisive weapon and the decisive wound. Paul Verhoeven's *Starship Troopers* (1997), with its interpolated propaganda newsreels, recovers by satire the critique of the official story that *Armor* had conducted by testimony. Steakley's novel stands at the head of this line, and its neglect by criticism distorts the history of the subgenre.

For trauma studies, the cold berserk offers a category for a phenomenon the literature has struggled to name: dissociative hyper-competence that presents as excellence and is therefore seldom treated as injury. The novel's sequence, from second skin to violent unshelling, through a degraded teneral life, to re-armoring as gift and finally to a community of witness, maps with uncanny exactness onto the stages of recovery that Judith Herman described in *Trauma and Recovery* (1992): safety, remembrance and mourning, reconnection. It also adds what clinical models tend to omit: that recovery may require someone else to bear the cost of opening the shell.

For media theory, the recorder anticipates the first-person archive of twenty-first-century war and poses its central question with unusual clarity: whether recorded experience is consumed as spectacle or received as testimony. For the philosophy of technology, the novel's skepticism about the cyborg acquires new pertinence as powered exoskeletons become engineering programs for soldiers and industrial workers alike. *Armor* does not oppose such devices. It asks what they will do to the persons inside them, and who will be there when the shells come off.

CODA: RECORDED COMPETENCE

One further resonance belongs to the present. Contemporary machine learning has made a large wager on the proposition that competence can be distilled from recorded behavior: that policies for acting in the world can be learned by imitating demonstrations, and that vast archives of human conduct contain, implicitly, the skills that produced them. *Armor* stages the same wager in 1984 and returns a sobering verdict. The battle recorder captures everything Felix lived through, with a fidelity no human memory could match, and no one who enters it emerges able to do what he did. The competence was never in the recording. What the recording could transmit, under the right conditions of witness, was something the period's epistemology had no column for: not a policy but a person, not how to survive but what to stand for. Whether that distinction will

survive the next generation of recording technologies is a question the novel cannot answer. It can only insist that the distinction is real.

THE SOFT HOUR

The first epigraph of this dissertation praised the man who could learn the causes of things and so trample on fear and inexorable fate. Felix never learns the causes. He tramples on fear only by dissociating from it, and fate he does not master but survives. If he is fortunate, *felix*, it is in the other sense the word carries: the sense of the Hesiodic heroes translated without a corpse to the edge of the world, whose people go on looking for them. The novel's final word, however, belongs not to the vanished hero but to those who keep looking and those who stay: the emissaries of Golden, who will not end their search, and the colony on Sanction, two of whose founders lived another man's life before beginning their own. Its narrator closes by recalling the Masao's teaching that there is no protection from what one is, adds that there is no protection from what one wants either, and ends on a question to the absent Felix: whether he is still there. *Armor* ends in the soft hour, after one shell has been shed and before another has hardened. That is where, on its account, a human being lives.



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Keywords

John Steakley; *Armor* (1984); military science fiction; exoskeletal subjectivity; powered armor; cold berserk; dissociation; psychological automatism; *Reizschutz*; repetition compulsion; moral injury; survivor guilt; psychic numbing; doubling; second skin; Skin-Ego; character armor; cyborg theory; philosophy of technology; prosthesis; autoamputation; dromology; logistics of perception; OODA loop; *Erlebnis* and *Erfahrung*; tertiary retention; tacit knowledge; testimony; spectacle; pseudo-event; recognition; the face; absolute enmity; insect sublime; superorganism; myrmecology; Myrmidons; autothysis; trickster; persona; celebrity; *hoplōn krisis*; Ajax; Odysseus; Myth of Er; Myth of the Metals; Isles of the Blessed; chiasmus; gift economy; ecdysis; teneral ethic; narratable self; precariousness; post-Vietnam fiction; *Starship Troopers*; *The Forever War*; *Ender's Game*; *Neuromancer*; *Vampire$*.